

"FOR ME, THE MONEY OF THE RICH, THE MIND OF THE MANAGERS, THE SWEAT OF THE LABOURERS... ALL THREE ARE A PART OF A FAMILY THAT LEADS TO DEVELOPMENT"

get its benefit, regardless of caste. So there should not be discrimination in governance, there should be secularism. We have not done 'Hindu-Muslim' anywhere. We are trying to explain their manifesto. I am telling Muslims that they are fooling you, they have been fooling you for 75 years. Why are you allowing them to do so?

Q: So you say you will never do 'Hindu-Muslim'.

I have never done 'Hindu-Muslim', nor will I do it in the future. But if I say triple talaq is wrong and you label me anti-Muslim, then that is your compulsion, not mine.

Q: On the subject of women. Women today have more agency and vote differently from men. How do you see things changing once 33 per cent reservation for women is implemented?

Even people from the West are astonished when I tell them that in India we give 26-week leave to pregnant women. We have built a perception in India that women are householders. This is not true. Look at our agriculture sector. Even today, the contribution of women in the sector is 60 per cent. But we have not been able to present this true picture to the world. Today, 15 per cent of commercial pilots in India are women—the highest for any country in the world.

Q: Women, we think, are your silent voters. But is it actually because all political parties are announcing freebies to attract their vote?

The issue is not really about women, it is whether political parties should empty their coffers to win elections. You build a Metro in a city. And then you announce free rides for women in the same city to win elections. This means you have taken out 50 per cent of the passengers for the Metro, making it unviable. Will we build it in the future or not? That is the concern.

Q: In the next five years, what will India's role be at the global high table?

The earlier narrative was that we maintain equal distance, that was the language of diplomacy. I said, nothing doing. In my language, everyone should be close. Earlier, there was a competition to stay away, now everyone is competing to get close to us. Also, we do not take our decisions based on some third person. We take our own decisions. I talk to everyone. If President Putin praises me, it does not mean that I cannot tell him that this is not the time for war. When our intentions are good, people trust you. I have no hidden agenda. I tell the Americans, I don't ask them. If my country needs cheap oil from Russia, I will take it, as it is important for me. I will not hide it. I run the country on my own terms.

Q: What do you hope your legacy to be?

I have been asked this before. I am surprised. A person who lives for the country, why will he think about himself? I don't work so that people remember me. If they have to remember anything, it should be the 40 per cent voter turnout in Kashmir after 40 years, and celebrate the festival of democracy. Think about the G20, where people praised India. Think of the time India will become the third-largest economy. What does Modi have to do with it? Hundreds of people like me will come and go. ■